

# The Long Way Home

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is brave, loyal, and full of ideas. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



*Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.*

### Before you begin

The long quarrel is over, and it ended not with spears but with friendship. The great gates of Troy stand open, and now it is time to sail home across the Wine-Dark Sea. Far away waits the Weaving Hall, where a warm fire, a homecoming feast, and old friends are ready for you.

Odysseus the Bright walks you down to the ships on the long sandy beach. "It is a long way home," he says, "and the sea is wide. But you are full of ideas, you are brave, and you keep faith with your friends. That is all a sailor truly needs."

He gives you three gifts for the journey: a great spiral Conch Horn, a Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of strong thread, Penelope's Thread. Then he smiles. "Out there we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, loyal, and full of ideas."



*What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Imagination, of Courage, or of Loyalty?*

### Stop 1 The Isle of Winds

You sail for many days until you come to a floating island ringed with shining bronze cliffs. This is the Isle of Winds, where Aeolus, Keeper of the Winds, lives. He keeps all the winds of the world tied up safe in a great leather bag.

Aeolus is kind, but he is careful. He will only lend a fair wind to travellers who ask with a good idea and politely, and who are not greedy. "Ask me nicely," he says, "and never, ever peek inside the wind-bag."



*How will you ask for a fair wind? Could you think of good, kind words to say? Could you promise not to peek inside the bag? What do you try?*

When you ask with a good idea and kindly, Aeolus laughs and ties a gentle wind into your sail. "A fair wind for friends," he says, and waves you off across the water.

### Stop 2 The Singing Sirens

For a long while you sail on. Then you hear it: a song floating over the sea, beautiful and so very sad. It comes from the Singing Sirens, sea-singers who sit on the lonely rocks. Their song is so lonely that ships drift off course just to follow it.

This is not a danger to run from. Listen closely. The Sirens are not wicked at all. They are only lonely, because nobody ever stays to be their friend.



*This is not a fight, and it is not a race to escape. What kind thing could you do? You could sing a song back to them. You could sound the Conch Horn. You could share your Basket of Honey and Figs. What do you try?*

When you answer their loneliness with kindness, the Sirens stop their sad song. They laugh, they wave, and they begin to sing a bright and happy tune that guides your ship safely past the rocks. "Come back and visit us!" they call.

### Stop 3 Home at Last

At last, far ahead, you see a shore you know. Your heart beats fast. Is this really home? You must look closely and be sure.

You step onto the sand and find the path up to the Weaving Hall. There, through the door, you can see the great loom where a friend has been weaving while you were away. An old friend looks up. And there, by the fire, an old dog lifts his grey head and sniffs the air.



*How will you know you are truly home? What do you remember about this place? Look for the loom, for an old friend, for the faithful hound. Who waits by the fire?*

It is Argos the Faithful Hound! He has never forgotten you. He trots up, his tail wagging so hard it nearly knocks him over, and you are home at last.

### Home at Last

The Weaving Hall is warm and full of light. The homecoming feast is laid out: warm bread, sweet figs, and honey. Old friends hug you and call your hero name. Argos the Faithful Hound will not leave your side.

High above the calm water, Thetis the Sea-Mother smiles down on you. You crossed the whole Wine-Dark Sea and came home together. You were brave, you were full of ideas, and most of all you kept faith with your friends. Well done, heroes. Welcome home.

# The Long Way Home: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works; read it once and you are set. This page holds only what is special about this story. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, with a wide sea and a long voyage and the pull of a lonely song, but good ideas and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

## Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp on the shores of Troy.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one or two of the five qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart on a wide sea), **Loyalty** (keeping faith with a friend), **Cleverness** (a clever, kind idea), or **Patience** (waiting and trying again). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: any spiral shell or cup for the Conch Horn, a small basket or token for the Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of string for Penelope's Thread. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

## The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

| Roll | Twist of Fate                                                     |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Odysseus the Bright gives you one free hint.                      |
| 2    | You find your sea-legs again, and take back one energy star.      |
| 3    | A fair wind fills the sail, and the next challenge is Easy.       |
| 4    | Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well. |
| 5    | A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.      |
| 6    | A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.         |

## How it ends

The Singing Sirens by the rocks are the "obstacle" of the voyage, but they are no villains. They are sea-singers who have been lonely too long, and their sad song pulls ships off course only because no one has ever stopped to befriend them. The tale is won not by fleeing them and not by any kind of force, but by answering their loneliness with kindness: a song sung back, the Conch Horn sounded, the Basket of Honey and Figs shared. Once the Sirens are cheered and befriended, they sing the heroes safely on their way. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. The last stop is the gentle joy of coming home to the Weaving Hall. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

# The Long Way Home: Puzzles and Solutions

*For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.*

## Stop 1: The Isle of Winds (Normal)

**The challenge.** Aeolus, Keeper of the Winds, will lend a fair wind only to travellers who ask him with a good idea and courteously, and who are not greedy enough to peek inside his wind-bag. The players must win his help with good manners and a good, honest request.

**The riddle.** If your heroes enjoy a puzzle, let Aeolus set one before he agrees: "*I have no hands, yet I fill a sail. I have no voice, yet I make the whole sea wail. You cannot see me, catch me, or keep me in a sack for long. What am I?*" The answer is **the wind** itself.

**Intended solution.** This is a challenge of Imagination and Courage. The bright, courteous move is to ask Aeolus plainly and politely for just a fair wind home, to thank him, and to promise faithfully not to untie the wind-bag to peek inside. Solving his little wind riddle works just as well. Reward good manners, an honest request, and any promise not to be greedy.

**Fallback.** If the children are stuck, have Aeolus give them a warm hint ("A kind word and a promise are all I ask, young sailors") or let them spend an energy star to find the right words together. A request made bravely and politely always earns the fair wind.

**Make it simpler.** Ask a little one to say "please" and blow a big puff of breath like the wind, and Aeolus happily sends them on their way.

## Stop 2: The Singing Sirens (Hard, then no roll)

**The challenge.** The Singing Sirens sit on the lonely rocks, and their song is so sad and so lovely that it pulls ships off course. The players may feel this is a danger to flee, or even to fight. It is neither.

**Intended solution.** This is a moment of Loyalty (kindness) and Courage. The Sirens are not wicked, only lonely; no one has ever stayed to be their friend. Any genuine kindness works: singing a warm song back to them, sounding the **Conch Horn** so its friendly note reaches the rocks, sharing the **Basket of Honey and Figs**, or simply calling out a kind hello. When the children answer the loneliness with kindness, the Sirens cheer up, and their bright new song guides the ship safely past the rocks. There is no roll to escape; the kindness is the answer.

**Fallback.** If the children freeze, or want to "win" by rowing away as fast as they can, have one Siren call across the water, very softly, "Will nobody ever stop and sing with us?" A single kind word or note from the Conch Horn turns the sad song glad and the Sirens become friends at once.

**Make it simpler.** Let a little one hum a happy "la-la-la" back to the Sirens, and that cheerful tune is all it takes to make them smile.

## Stop 3: Home at Last (Normal)

**The challenge.** The heroes reach a green shore that may be home. They must cross the last stretch and be sure, then recognise the Weaving Hall and the friends waiting inside.

**Intended solution.** This is a moment of Loyalty and Observation. The bright and loyal move is to remember the marks of home: the great loom standing in the firelight, the face of an old friend, and above all **Argos the Faithful Hound** by the hearth, who knows them at once. Naming what they remember, or calling the old dog's name, settles it beyond doubt and the homecoming begins.

**Fallback.** If the children are unsure whether this is truly home, let Argos settle it: the old hound lifts his grey head, catches their scent, and trots straight to them with his tail wagging, because he has never once forgotten a friend. Recognising home with the dog's help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

**Make it simpler.** Ask a little one to call out the dog's name, "Argos!", and give a big happy wave, and the homecoming begins right away.

## The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the heroes step into the Weaving Hall, the homecoming feast is laid, old friends call them by their hero names, Argos the Faithful Hound will not leave their side, and far out on the calm sea **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles up at them. The whole Wine-Dark Sea is crossed and the long way home is done. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, loyal, and full of ideas.

# Wander and Tales

## Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.